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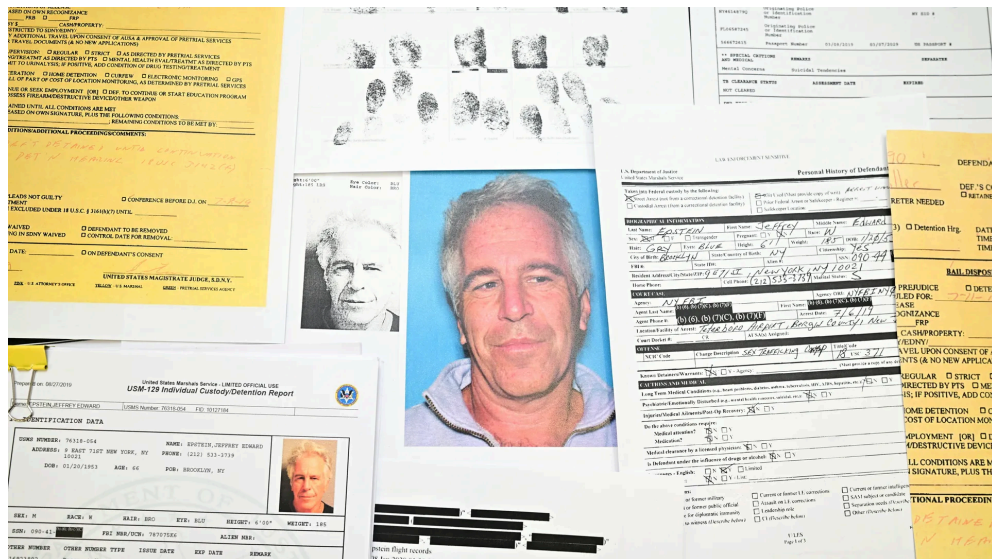
Inside Epstein's efforts to influence global elites



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Handouts of released documents related to court cases against late financier and convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, issued by the U.S. Justice Department, are seen printed and arranged. Photo Illustration: Vladislav Nekrasov/SOPA Images/LightRocket via Getty Images

The Justice Department's release of millions of documents related to convicted sex offender Jeffrey [Epstein](#) shows how

Why it matters: Epstein's [network of connections](#) was "extraordinary," Sarah Krissoff, a former U.S. attorney in the Southern District of New York, tells Axios. "Power is one of those things that keeps expanding. He traveled in ultra-rich circles, and, from what I have seen, worked hard to cultivate relationships."

- While being named in the Epstein files does not indicate wrongdoing, the fallout from the documents' release has triggered a [wave of firings](#) and resignations, and has prompted several countries to launch investigations.
- "I don't think this story is over yet," Krissoff says. She didn't directly work on the case that the SDNY was prosecuting against the disgraced financier before his [2019 death](#), but worked closely with the prosecutors who did.
- "From what I have seen, he worked hard to cultivate his circle of contacts."

Here's a look at the global ripples of the scandal:

Russia and Eastern Europe

It's clear that Epstein made several attempts to meet with [Russian](#) President Vladimir Putin in the 2010s, including through his apparent relationship with former Norwegian Prime Minister Thorbjørn Jagland.

- In a May [2013](#) email apparently sent to Israel's former Prime Minister Ehud Barak, Epstein writes that Jagland "is going to see putin in sochi" and had asked that Epstein make himself available for a meeting in June "to explain how russia can structure deals in order to encourage

- In a [2018](#) email, Jagland appears to agree to suggest to Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov's assistant that he help arrange a meeting for Epstein. There's no evidence that Epstein ever met with Putin or Lavrov.
- In that same exchange, Epstein claims he'd previously been in touch with [Vitaly Churkin](#), Russia's permanent representative to the UN from 2006 until his 2017 death.

Churkin features several times in the files, including [in 2016](#) texts in which Epstein agrees to provide "confidential" help to get Churkin's son a job in the U.S.

- Another influential [Russian](#) with whom Epstein appears to have [corresponded](#) was [Sergey Belyakov](#), who [served](#) as Deputy Minister of Economic Development from 2012-14 and also studied at an academy for intelligence personnel.
- In a 2015 [email](#) apparently sent to tech mogul Peter Thiel, Epstein describes Belyakov as "my very good friend" and refers to their work on a conference in Moscow.

Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk [announced](#) an investigation into potential ties between Epstein and Russian intelligence and whether any Polish women or girls were [impacted](#) by the case.

- The Kremlin [rejects](#) allegations that Epstein was a [spy](#) for Russia.
- [Latvia](#) and [Lithuania](#) have also opened investigations into potential human trafficking related to the Epstein files.

- That included light-hearted texts in 2018 about women and an upcoming meeting between Lajčák and Lavrov, [documents](#) released by the DOJ show.
- Lajčák [told](#) Radio Slovakia after resigning last week that his messages were "nothing more than foolish male egos in action" and there "were no girls," per a EuroNews [translation](#). "The fact that someone is communicating with a sexual predator does not make him a sexual predator," Lajčák added.

U.K.

Prime Minister Keir Starmer is [under intense pressure](#) for appointing [Peter Mandelson](#) as ambassador to Washington despite his links to Epstein.

- Starmer fired Mandelson after the latest batch of files suggested he'd passed market-sensitive information to Epstein while serving as a government minister during the 2008 global financial crisis.
- Other documents suggest that Mandelson and his husband received [payments](#) from Epstein in 2003-2004.
- Mandelson has said he has no recollection of such payments and apologized for his association with Epstein. He told the [BBC](#) last month that he was "wrong to believe him following his conviction and to continue my association with him afterwards."
- Starmer's chief of staff Morgan McSweeney [resigned](#) Sunday after taking responsibility for Mandelson's appointment.

files.

- He was stripped last year of his royal and nobility titles over his ties to the convicted sex offender.
- The latest documents include photos that appear to show the former prince [kneeling](#) over a woman lying on the floor.
- Other documents suggest that Andrew may have knowingly shared confidential information with Epstein about his official work as trade envoy for the U.K. in 2010 and 2011, per the [BBC](#).

Israel

The files indicate that Barak, the former prime minister, and his wife stayed at Epstein's apartment multiple times from 2015 to 2019, [according](#) to Israeli media [reports](#).

- Barak has [said](#) he "deeply regrets" his past relationship with Epstein and that he never saw nor participated in any inappropriate behavior during their meetings.
- Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu [rejected](#) conspiracy theories [peddled](#) online that his longtime political rival Barak's "unusual close relationship" indicated that Epstein was an Israeli [spy](#).

Norway

Police opened an investigation last week into Jagland, the former chair of the Norwegian Nobel Committee and Secretary General of the Council of Europe, "based on information in the Epstein-files."

a [statement](#) from Økokrim, Norway's central authority for fighting economic and environmental crimes. Investigators have asked for Jagland's immunity to be lifted.

- Jagland maintains that his contact with Epstein was "part of [normal diplomatic](#) activity" and his lawyer [told](#) reporters he'll cooperate with the investigation and is "confident" of its outcome. He has not been charged with any crimes.

Norway's crown princess, Mette-Marit, has also publicly [apologized](#) after the documents appeared to show extensive friendly correspondence with Epstein from 2011 to 2014, years after his 2008 conviction.

France

Former Culture Minister Jack Lang resigned on Saturday as president of the Arab World Institute after French financial crime prosecutors [announced](#) a preliminary inquiry into him and his daughter on suspicion of "aggravated tax fraud laundering" after he was mentioned in the Epstein files.

- Both deny any wrongdoing and the 86-year-old [said](#) on X that he welcomed the investigation.

Epstein also asked contacts to put him in touch with French politicians including President Emmanuel Macron and former President Nicolas Sarkozy, the documents show, but there's no evidence he was successful.

Australia

Epstein wrote in a 2014 email to former Treasury Secretary [Larry Summers](#) that former Australian Prime Minister

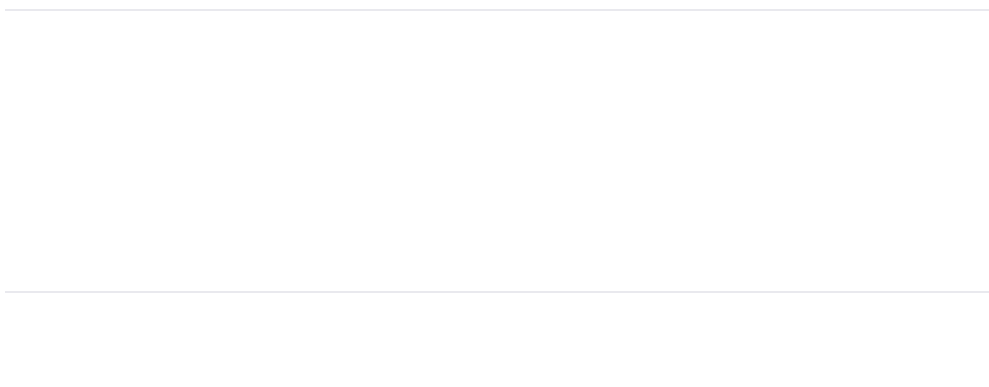
- Later that year, he wrote to his assistant that they should have "non vegetarin [sic] food" available because Rudd would be joining.
- However, Rudd's office said in a [statement](#) there are "no records" of the pair meeting and that Epstein's reps had been "unsuccessful" in arranging an introduction.

What to watch: More could emerge about Epstein's global network as members of Congress [review the unredacted files](#).

Go deeper: [Epstein file review yields 6 new "likely incriminated" men, lawmakers say](#)



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